

God's Exaltation in Finances

God Can Exalt Finances Beyond the Limits of Circumstances

God's exaltation in your finances is what we are dealing with this morning.

Luke 14:11 says:

For whosoever exalteth himself shall be abased;
And he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

It took me a measly four or five years to understand that the exaltation Jesus is talking about here is exaltation that comes to a man in the kingdom of God. There are several ways a man can be exalted: in his calling, in anointings, in the presence of God, and in peace. The exaltation we are dealing with this morning is exaltation in finances.

If God comes along, puts His hand on your shoulder, and blows on your finances, figuratively speaking, your circumstances do not matter. His supply is not limited to this world. He promised givers that He would supply their needs according to His riches in glory. That is a heavenly standard according to anointing, and I have never heard of heaven having a recession.

As long as He is supplying my needs according to His riches in glory, and as long as I walk with Him, I cannot really see anything He asks us to lay our hands on not prospering.

When God's exaltation kicks into your life, it does not matter what circumstances say. It does not matter what the devil says. When God says, "Come up higher," you and your finances are going higher, and there is nothing this side of hell the devil can do about it.

You can go to bed owing everybody in the world, somehow attain to His exaltation, and learn to humble yourself. He can blow on your circumstances during the night, and you can wake up in the morning with blessings coming from so many directions that you know God is God.

When I realized Luke 14:11 was talking about exaltation in the kingdom, the one thing I wanted to glean from the chapter was how to humble myself. If humbling myself results in the God kind of exaltation, then I want to know how to do it, not from men, but from God.

The Lowest Room Leads to Visible Exaltation Among Those Who Know You

Luke 14 says:

When thou art bidden of any man to a wedding, sit not down in the highest room;
Lest a more honourable man than thou be bidden of him;
And he that bade thee and him come and say to thee, Give this man place;
And thou begin with shame to take the lowest room.
But when thou art bidden, go and sit down in the lowest room;
That when he that bade thee cometh, he may say unto thee, Friend, go up higher.

If this is really talking about exaltation in the kingdom of God, then the man who invited you to the wedding is the Lord Jesus Christ. The wedding is the wedding supper, the supper prepared by God for the whole world through the Lamb.

Jesus is the One who bids you to come into the kingdom, and He is the One who comes, puts His hand on your shoulder, and says, "Friend, come up higher."

When Jesus puts His hand on your shoulder and says, "Friend, come up higher," your circumstances do not matter much. He can blow on your finances, and five minutes later you may barely remember you had a problem.

Jesus says that when He exalts you, you will have worship, or admiration, in the presence of those who sit at meat with you. These are the people you fellowship with, eat with, conduct daily affairs with, and who know you best. They know you like a book.

Something out of the ordinary has to happen in your life for the people closest to you to admire what God has done. That is the first level of exaltation: earthly blessing in the realm where we carry on daily affairs.

The Greater Exaltation Is Recompense at the Resurrection of the Just

The second level is in verse 14:

And thou shalt be blessed;
For they cannot recompense thee:
For thou shalt be recompensed at the resurrection of the just.

I used to want the earthly level more, but now I want the heavenly level more. I want rewards in heaven more than things on earth. That is a bold statement, and you can say it all you want, but until your heart gets there, it will not make much difference.

I am quickly coming to the place where I want His exaltation in heaven more than His exaltation on earth. But the tricky thing is that when you seek heaven's reward, it ends up bringing earth's blessings.

That is what Jesus meant when He said:

Seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness;
And all these things shall be added unto you.

The recompense of the just is the one I want most. Since entering into this incredible peace with my Father, I have found that the most sought-after blessing in all heaven is the reward of the Lamb bestowed on us for faithful service, the recompense of the just.

It is what the entire universe circles around. It is what the angels desire to look into: the gospel of salvation preached by men empowered by the Holy Ghost sent down from heaven. They do not have a chance for this reward. We do.

There will be billions in heaven who simply went to heaven with no reward. If they could pass through the cradle of humanity one more time, I guarantee you that after stepping onto the shores of heaven, they would esteem lifelong service as nothing compared to the recompense of the just.

That makes me want to know what Jesus wants me to do to humble myself.

True Servanthood Is Tested When People Wound You

I do not want men teaching me how to humble myself. We have as many opinions as we have churches. One will say, "Scrub the toilets." That can be part of humbling yourself as a servant, but many people come under an anointing, listen to a few tapes, and make enormous commitments.

"I have come to serve. I will be with you forever. I will do whatever you want. I will vacuum rugs. I am just here to serve."

They mean it when they say it. But the first little thing that de-exalts them comes along, just a little bit, and they are gone.

I asked God why people do that. I believe He revealed it to me over time. When they come, they believe what they are saying. It is part of repentance. They have a major character flaw they do not like, and when they commit their whole life again, it is like penance. But when the devil comes along and empowers the old fault a little, it takes them right back out.

I do not want man's exaltation. I want to make sure that if I humble myself, it is before God.

The Lord asked me, "You know I have a bunch of people who are full of faults, faultfinders, fighters, unfaithful, and not faithful to each other. A lot of them are a mess. Are you willing to die in servitude for them?"

I said, "I guess I have to, do I not? That is what a call is about."

He said:

He that is greatest among you shall be servant of all.

It is not hard to serve God when everything is going well, money is pouring in, and everybody is praising the place and praising you. But when the prayer center is under attack, people are calling you names, spitting in your face, leaving, saying you all pray too much, and doing you in right and left, and you can turn around and love them, that is the first sign of tremendous growth.

Love is not based on what people do for you. Love is based on what He has put in your heart. Start loving those people, and you will be exalted.

Inviting Those Who Cannot Repay Reveals the Heart Behind Giving

Now that we understand the two levels of exaltation, let us go back to verse 11:

Whosoever exalteth himself shall be abased;
And he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

Then Jesus continues:

When thou makest a dinner or a supper, call not thy friends, nor thy brethren,
Neither thy kinsmen, nor thy rich neighbours;
Lest they also bid thee again, and a recompence be made thee.
But when thou makest a feast, call the poor, the maimed, the lame, the blind:
And thou shalt be blessed; for they cannot recompense thee:
For thou shalt be recompensed at the resurrection of the just.

Jesus did not change the subject. He is giving instructions on how to take the lower room.

First, Jesus invites us to come to the wedding. He says, "Come to the kingdom, take the lowest room, and I assure you in this lifetime you will be exalted."

Now He says that once you are in the kingdom, you go out and make a supper. As a servant of God, you invite people to come and eat from the feast prepared by God through the Lord Jesus Christ.

We go from the man who accepted Jesus and took a position in the kingdom to the man who now invites others to come eat from the kingdom.

The instruction for exaltation is this: do not call only your relatives, friends, and rich neighbors, because recompense will be made back to you. Jesus begins examining the motivations of the heart. If I only invite people because inviting them will benefit me, then I have not taken the lowest room.

Why are so many churches geared toward fine middle-class people rather than the poor, the maimed, the lame, and the blind? Because if I invest into your life, I want you to have something to invest back into mine.

But Jesus says to call those who cannot recompense you.

Seed That Never Reaches the Lost and Broken Is Not Producing

The Spirit of the Lord was upon Jesus to preach the gospel to the poor, bring sight to the blind, set prisoners free, and release the captives. When you invite men to the supper, go get the poor, the maimed, the lame, and the blind. Bring them in, and you shall be blessed.

Jesus will come and put His hand on your shoulder and say, "Friend, come up higher," because the motivation of your heart is to minister to the poor, blind, lost, and broken because Jesus loves them.

If your seed is only sown before four walls that live and die inwardly, with no salvations, no outreach, and no ministry to the poor and broken, then your seed is not producing what Jesus is talking about.

This is why we have tackled Brazil so strongly. We are training preachers to bring this gospel to exactly that element. This is why that seed is so good.

This is why the prayer center is believing for land so we can build and go downtown, pick up busloads of broken people, and bring them into twenty-four hours of Word. We are heading that way as fast as we can.

If you want exaltation that comes on these two levels, then what is the motivation of your heart?

My wife once did me in. I had ten thousand dollars and had promised her I would do some things to the house. Then suddenly it came on me emotionally that God was telling me to sow that ten-thousand-dollar seed into a very influential ministry.

I told my wife, "God is telling me to sow this seed."

She said, "You promised me. But if it is God, I will go along with it. However, there is another ministry that will not have the foggiest notion where it came from. I want you to run the ten thousand through them and make them swear to silence, so the ministry you want to give it to will not know where it came from."

The next morning the emotions wore off, and I did not feel like giving it. I had to tell her, "You were right. Go fix the house."

That is exactly what Jesus is talking about. Do you want Jesus to blow on your finances? He can blow on them overnight until you barely know you had a problem.

Luke 6:38 Is About Showing Mercy to Sinners Who Cannot Repay You

Luke 6:38 is often quoted in giving services:

Give, and it shall be given unto you;

Good measure, pressed down, and shaken together, and running over, shall men give into your bosom.

For with the same measure that ye mete withal it shall be measured to you again.

God only knows how many times I have had that quoted to me. But if you think this does not support what Luke 14 teaches, look again. Back up to verse 36:

Be ye therefore merciful, as your Father also is merciful.

For the first time, I realized in meditation that I did not understand mercy because I did not understand the difference between mercy and grace. I was using grace where mercy belonged and mercy where grace belonged.

When humanity was lost on the other side of the void, we had no access to the Father. We had nothing to bargain with, no right even to bargain. We were lost.

God had mercy on us and sent Jesus across that void. Jesus humbled Himself and became obedient to the cross. His blood gave us something to approach God with. Mercy sent Him across the void. When we accepted the Lord Jesus Christ, grace kicked in: His unmerited favor gave us access to God.

What does that have to do with giving? Back up to verse 27:

Love your enemies, do good to them which hate you,

Bless them that curse you, and pray for them which despitefully use you.

And unto him that smiteth thee on the one cheek offer also the other;

And him that taketh away thy cloke forbid not to take thy coat also.

Jesus is talking about our relationship with the sinner and the world. When they despitefully use me, slap me, hate me, or sue me, my turning the other cheek is me showing mercy to them.

If they sue me for my car, I will get it tuned up, fill it with gas, and deliver it. Why? Because I am showing mercy. I am taking the blood of Jesus across that undeserving void and extending it to them, in case they want to take the grace of God and be born again.

My reward is that I will be a child of the Highest. If they take everything I have out the back door, God will heap it down, press it down, shake it together, and bring it in the front door because I bestowed mercy on someone who did not deserve it.

You cannot bankrupt God. That is what Luke 6:38 is about.

Believers Are Helped by Virtue, Not Enabled by Handouts

How about believers? Go to 2 Thessalonians 3.

I know God wants me to extend mercy across that void to the sinner, but a believer comes under another category. I will instruct, exhort, and even rebuke, because the answer to all your problems is virtue. Virtue is the application of Scripture to every situation.

Paul says:

For yourselves know how ye ought to follow us:
For we behaved not ourselves disorderly among you;
Neither did we eat any man's bread for nought;
But wrought with labour and travail night and day,
That we might not be chargeable to any of you.

Some people left the prayer center because I did not pressure you to raise the large down payments on this building. I presented the building and the opportunity to give, but I will not come out and beg as though God is letting me down.

God did institute giving to meet the needs of ministry, but if that system breaks down, this ministry still does not stand or fall because of dependency on another human being. Your stand or fall is based on dependency on the Lord Jesus Christ. That is the application of virtue.

This ministry will not fail if none of you give. I will not subconsciously instill unbelief in you by begging. I love you too much. You will never get from me a reflection of a God who can fail you.

If you want to give from your heart, not for recompense or self-exaltation, then give to meet needs, for the kingdom's sake, and out of the new nature He put in you. But do not give because I beg or shift all responsibility onto you.

No human being will ever determine whether you stand or fall. If you are in the Amazon and need support, God can convert someone there and bring what is needed. Do not ever beg. Submit your gift to servitude. Do not sell your gift for money. Do not preach for it, sing for it, or minister for it, or you will stop being exalted.

The answer to every problem is virtue, the application of the Word of God to the given situation.

Disorderly Believers Must Be Pressed Toward Work and Responsibility

Paul continues:

Not because we have not power,
But to make ourselves an ensample unto you to follow us.
For even when we were with you, this we commanded you,
That if any would not work, neither should he eat.

Paul had a right to eat from the altar, but he would not do it in that situation because he was protecting their testimony. He says if a man will not work, he should not eat. This is virtue: the application of Scripture to a given situation.

This is a believer, not a sinner. A sinner can bankrupt me, slap me, sue me, and take my goods, and I will show him mercy. But when it comes to a believer, the application of virtue says an able-bodied man should work.

Sitting around believing God has never done anybody any good if it is a cloak for laziness. If Paul could carry on an apostolic ministry and work, then do not tell me you cannot work.

Paul says:

For we hear that there are some which walk among you disorderly,
Working not at all, but are busybodies.

If you have money, your family is supplied, and you do not have to work, that is fine. People with money do not have to work unless they want to. But they cannot become busybodies, mooching and begging for handouts under the guise of religion or ministry.

If you are able to make your own way and you lie down, somebody is carrying you. You have doubled somebody else's load.

When God alerted me to professional beggars who move through churches taking advantage of big-hearted believers, I changed my approach. I would rather hire a person to stand there and watch them work than give them money that destroys character.

One man came through with his family bankrupt. We put him up, fed him, and did everything. Later we found out he had lost his job and spent a week and a half at a friend's house eating steak every day while we took on the burden and ate oatmeal. He would sneak off as if going to work.

Later he came through town with his second family and wanted to move in. I said no. He said, "I remember the day you would give me the shirt off your back."

I said, "That was before I could recognize a welfare spirit. However, you can clean the porch and do some work, and then I will give you that sack of cans to cash in."

He said, "You think I am going to?"

"Goodbye."

Paul says:

Now them that are such we command and exhort by our Lord Jesus Christ,
That with quietness they work, and eat their own bread.
But ye, brethren, be not weary in well doing.
And if any man obey not our word by this epistle, note that man,
And have no company with him, that he may be ashamed.
Yet count him not as an enemy, but admonish him as a brother.

Do not make the circumstances they are living under comfortable. Turn the pressure up, loaf of bread at a time. Do not just give them money; buy groceries if you must, and press them toward responsibility.

Any time someone says, "God told me to quit my job, sit in my apartment, and pray," and then goes broke while bills stack up, God did not tell him that. He probably did not pray much when he was working either.